Teaching Dossier

Jacob Zimbelman
Saint Louis University

TABLE OF CONTENTS

§1 Teaching Statement 1

§2 Evidence of Teaching Excellence 3

§2.1 Quantitative Overview: Six Charts 3

§2.2 Qualitative Overview: Four Themes 6

§3 Sample Materials 8

§1 Teaching Statement

In my time at Saint Louis University, I've gained over five years of teaching experience. For two years, I served as a teaching assistant for some of SLU's most experienced philosophy instructors. And for the last three and a half years, I've designed and taught my own courses as a sole instructor with a 2-2 teaching load. I'm happy to say that these experiences have helped me to learn what works and does not work for me and for my students in the classroom.

At SLU, I was encouraged by my faculty mentors to approach teaching "like a mad scientist," trying new pedagogical techniques and approaches regularly. I took this advice to heart and tried out a number of different teaching styles. Nowadays, I've settled on two main approaches that I enjoy and find to be effective, each for different reasons. Both kinds of approaches heavily emphasize full-class discussions, where students and I talk together as a single unit rather than breaking into small groups or pairs. The primary distinction between the two models lies in who officially leads these conversations.

In courses of the first kind, *I* lead class discussions—typically with the aid of detailed handouts. Most classes start with an activity of some kind that makes use of the board, for instance categorizing things as instrumentally or intrinsically valuable (or both) before discussing well-being; or making a list of beautiful things before discussing the sun, divided line, and cave from Plato's *Republic*. Other times, I start class with a piece of media, such as the 10-minute episode of the show *Love, Death, and Robots*, in which a sapient and artistic robot gives up his higher functions in order to enjoy the simple existence of an automated pool-cleaner. My aim is to begin class with something visually engaging that can anchor and inspire discussion, especially for those students who tend to find philosophy excessively abstract.

I then move on to the handout. Its primary purpose is to guide students through an in-depth reflection on carefully selected arguments or readings. I intentionally choose arguments that are either provocative enough to promote lively discussion or that defend claims which are relevant in some way to topics covered elsewhere in the course. For example, I introduce the problem of induction mid-semester, which sets the stage for proposing theism as a potential solution toward the end of the term. Similarly, in the first unit of my intro class, I weave together discussions about well-being, personal identity, virtue, and the fear of death so students can see how these topics interconnect.

Crucially, these (rather lengthy!) handouts model effective philosophical reasoning. By outlining arguments, defending premises, and addressing potential objections, they provide a blueprint for students to emulate in their three short essays. I also intentionally draft these handouts so as to anticipate student contributions. As a result, when a student raises an observation or objection in class, I am often prepared to point them to relevant material from a section of the handout.

The primary advantage of this approach is that it empowers students, regardless of their background, to discuss philosophical concepts at a high—and thus engaging—level. The detailed handouts add substance and depth to the contributions of less advanced students. At the same time, they give more advanced students plenty to chew on. However, the model's reliance on essay-based assessment has become something of a drawback. While grading three short essays per semester isn't inherently overburdensome, the rise of AI-generated work has made it increasingly taxing. Seeking a teaching model that didn't force me into the role of an AI detector, I tried a few different things, ultimately settling on a second, distinct approach to my philosophy courses.

In courses of the second kind, my *students* lead our discussions, though I still take part in the conversation. In place of short essays, these student-led sessions serve as the primary graded assignments. Working in pairs or small groups, every student is responsible for leading the class twice over the course of the semester. During these sessions, the leaders must offer and defend a specific answer to the day's assigned philosophical question (e.g., "What's truth?" or "Does it make sense to have children?"). This requires them to provide solid arguments in favor of their position, raise arguments against it, and respond to these objections. Having done this, their primary role for the remainder of class is to facilitate a unified conversation—fielding questions, asking follow-ups, and easing their peers into collaborative inquiry. Students are graded on how well they defend their own view, how well they facilitate discussion, and how well they prepare for these two tasks.

Because leading discussion is a demanding and somewhat intimidating assignment, leaders are required to meet with me at least a week in advance so I can help them plan their strategies, avoid pitfalls, and address potential objections. These meetings present opportunities for me to have sustained, in-depth philosophical conversations with students in small groups of two or three. In these conversations, I encourage my students to think more deeply about the questions and readings by raising questions and presenting objections myself. On one hand, this prepares discussion leaders for the sorts of objections and questions their peers might raise. On the other, it builds the skills required for philosophical inquiry in the discussion leaders themselves. It's an enjoyable and rewarding feature of this course model that some of the most serious learning occurs outside of a formal classroom setting.

To further support our discussions, I begin each class with a brief reading quiz. Some of these are rigorous, requiring students to accurately reproduce a key argument or distinction from the assigned text. Others, however, are more tongue-in-cheek and serve as playful conversation starters. For instance, a quiz on Descartes' *Meditations* asks students to conclusively demonstrate the existence of minds other than their own. Another favorite is a multiple-choice quiz asking students whether they have free will—where the only available option is 'No.'

Courses of this kind tend to produce classroom discussions that are more lively, inclusive, and effortless than I previously thought possible in general education courses. Moreover, this model naturally alleviates my AI-induced grading blues: effectively facilitating a live discussion requires students to have genuinely thought things through for themselves, so AI tools can't do the work for them. For these reasons, the student-led approach is especially enjoyable for me. However, there's a trade-off for my more advanced students. Because student-led conversations are generally less focused and less philosophically rigorous than those I lead myself, students with a strong background in the subject may not find them as challenging or interesting.

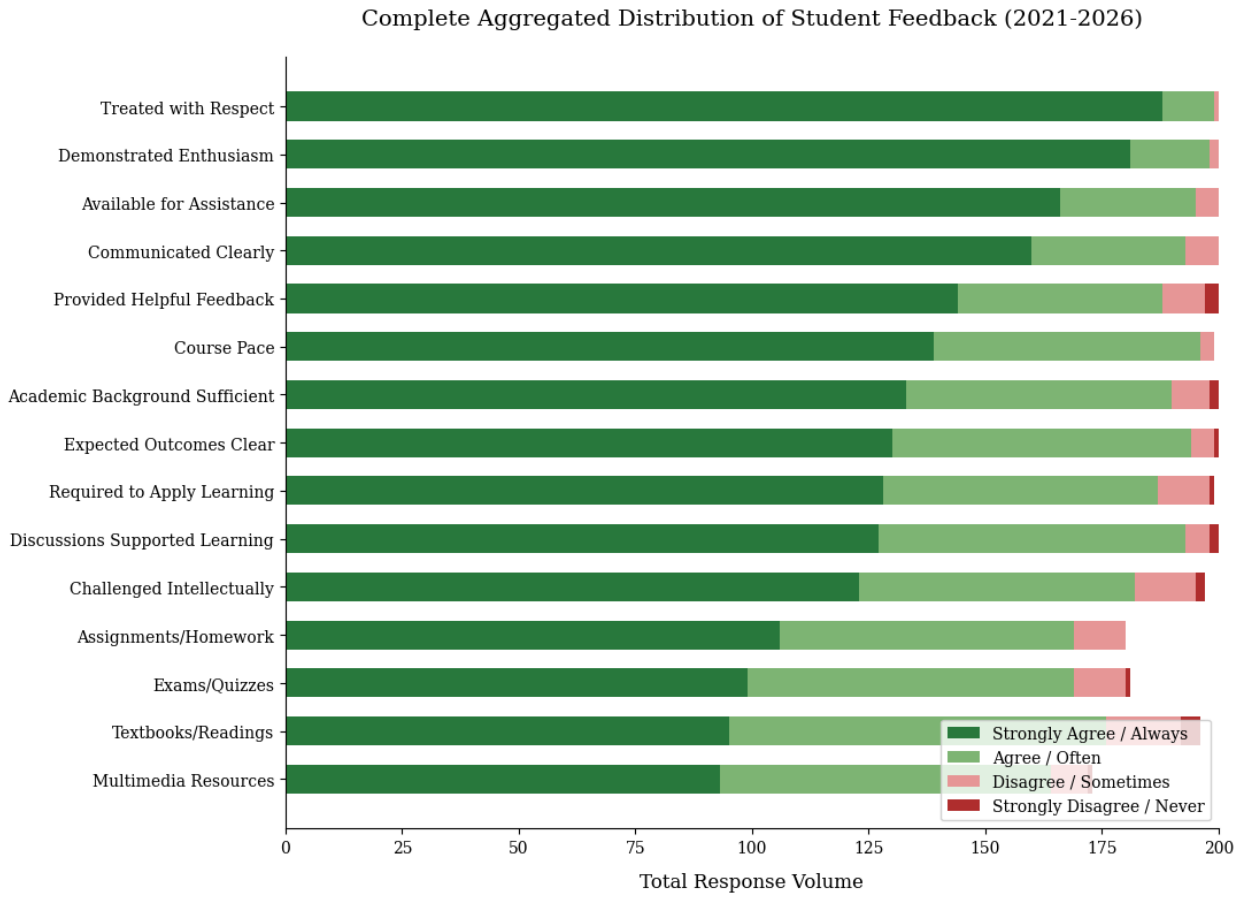
As I continue to teach, I'm committed to improving both of these models, whether by synthesizing them to address their individual weaknesses or by refining them as separate, distinct approaches. Moreover, though I have grown passionate about teaching general education students, I also welcome the opportunity to apply these methods in upper-level and interdisciplinary environments. For instance, I would love to teach a dedicated course on the epistemology of conspiracy theories or on media ethics. I can readily envision the student-led model working well in a capstone seminar for philosophy majors. Meanwhile, I have already had the opportunity to successfully pilot the structured handout method with majors at Pepperdine University's philosophy club, yielding excellent results. Ultimately, I remain deeply committed to my ongoing growth as an educator, and I look forward to tailoring my teaching strategies to the specific needs of my future students and department.

§2 Evidence of Teaching Excellence

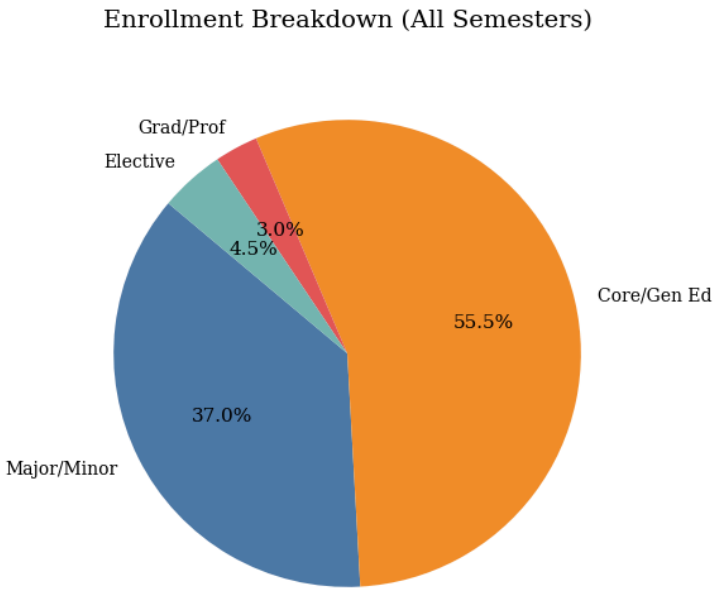
I've taught almost 400 students in 19 classroom sections across 10 semesters. Throughout, I've received a great deal of student feedback. Below, I provide an overview of the quantitative and qualitative data from students' formal evaluations of my courses and me. You're welcome to peruse the raw data, which I've made available in this folder.

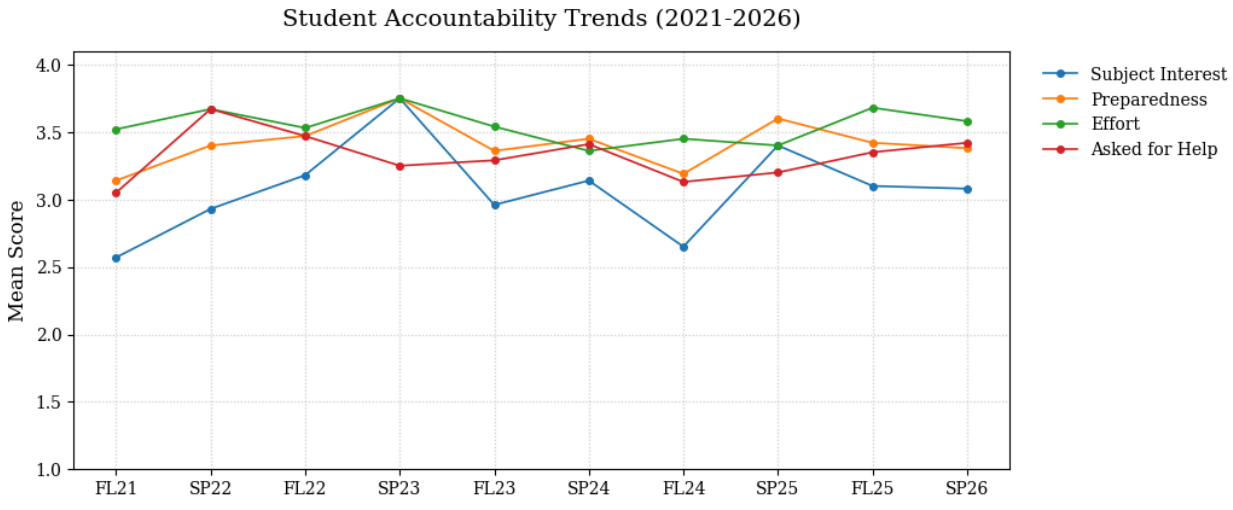
§2.1 Quantitative Overview: Six Charts

Across ten academic terms (2021–2026) and 19 course sections, my student evaluation data demonstrates a sustained record of instructional excellence, strong student rapport, and pedagogical rigor. Evaluating feedback from 200 student responses—over 55% of whom enrolled solely to fulfill core general education requirements—the trends show that I consistently bridge low initial subject interest with high classroom effort and active engagement. Throughout five years of teaching, student ratings concerning my respect for students (3.82–4.00/4.00) and enthusiasm for the material (3.82–4.00/4.00) have remained consistently near-perfect. This high student approval coexists with high academic standards: students routinely rate my courses as intellectually challenging (averaging up to 3.75/4.00) while identifying class discussion as their primary driver of learning.

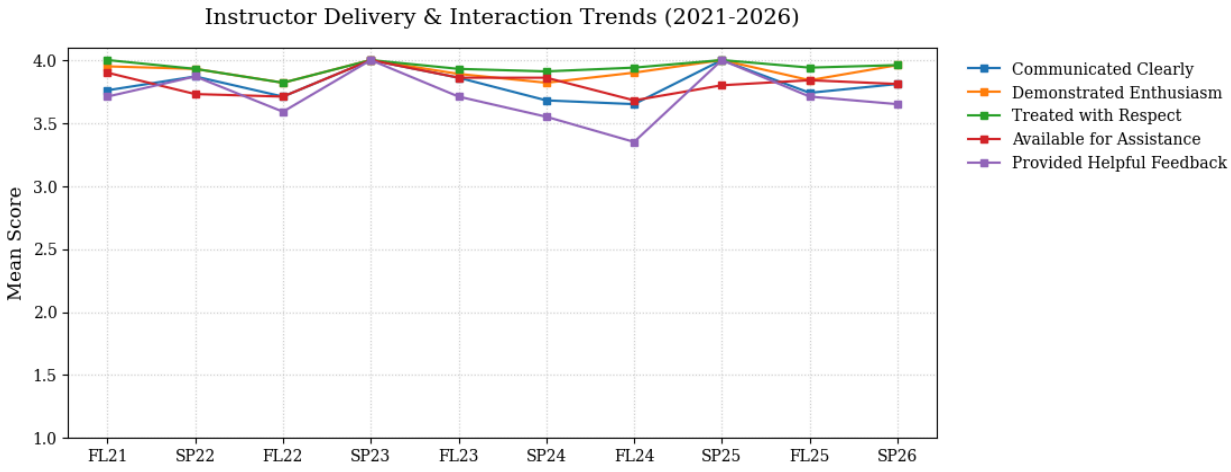


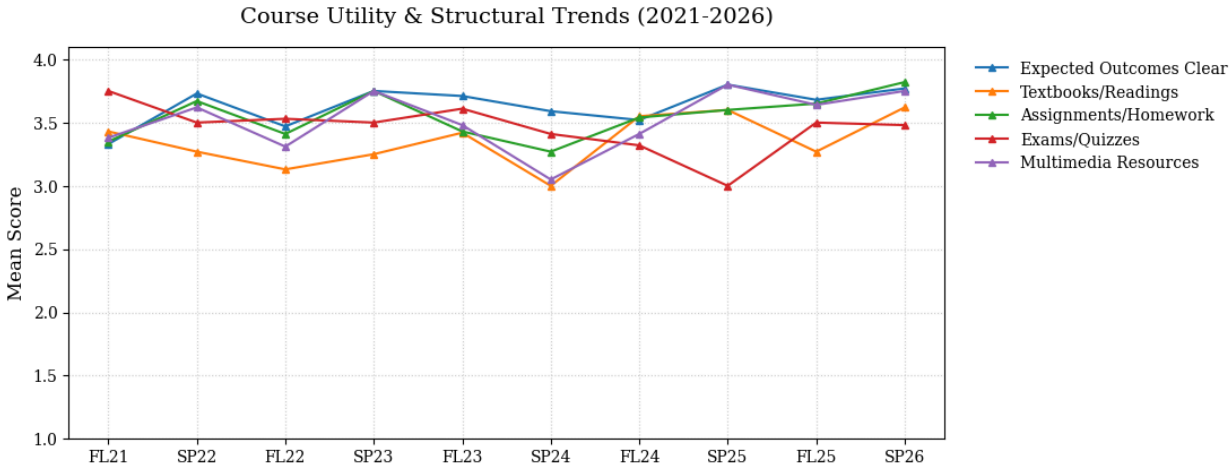
Aggregating all 15 quantitative metrics from 200 student evaluations reveals an overwhelming concentration of ratings in the highest possible categories (Strongly Agree / Always), with negative feedback accounting for a negligible fraction of total responses.

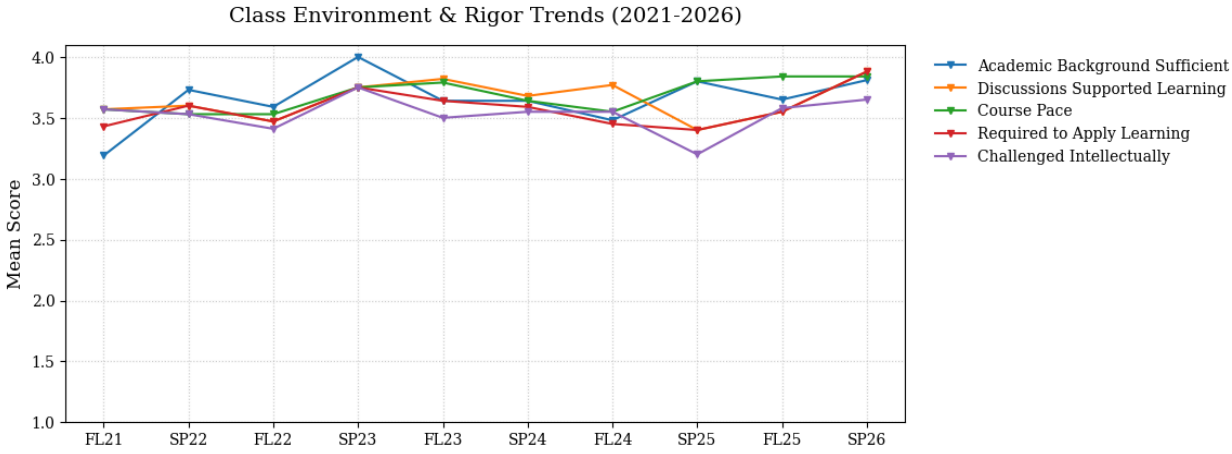




I teach a diverse cross-section of the undergraduate student body, with over 55% of students enrolling to fulfill university core obligations and 37% completing ethics requirements for professional majors such as Business and Nursing. These students routinely report low initial interest in philosophy.







I've experimented with my course design and instructional approach over the years, with some changes working better than others. These charts show that my teaching achieves high student satisfaction regardless.

§2.2 Qualitative Overview: Four Themes

The selected student reflections below represent four recurring themes I've noticed in my course evaluations. You can see the totality of qualitative feedback I've received here.

Engaging Discussions

- He is a fantastic teacher who likes to focus on in class discussion and collaboration. This makes for a really engaging and interesting class experience unlike many others that I have seen before. Usually when teachers want students to engage in discussion they ask them to get into small groups and talk amongst themselves. This class however is completely different. Instead Professor Zimbelman guides the class through a discussion that hits all the major talking points of the class but also allows us to explore what we want to talk about and what our thoughts are on ethics and how it applies to the real world.

- Even though I came into this class not being interested at all, you did a great job of keeping me interested in what was being taught and made me think about different perspectives I might not have thought of before. The class discussions were my favorite part of the class and kept me engaged. You also did a great job of trying to explain things to me when I did not understand an idea fully.

Changing Attitudes Toward Philosophy

- Jacob was one of my favorite professors I had at SLU this semester. Philosophy has never been a subject that interests me strongly, yet Jacob made this class very engaging and interactive which led to my interest in philosophy rising and thoroughly enjoying this course. He was always very energetic and enthusiastic about the class and while he is lecturing. He was very fair to every student and made sure everyone was engaged, in hopes of bettering our education and learning. Overall I loved having Jacob as a professor.

- It was in incredible class! I took it as a core requirement and it turned out being very interesing and opened me up to a lot of new ideas. I've already began looking at a lot of philosophers and texts we talked about in class!

- I really enjoyed this class even though I was not very interested in philosophy before taking this class. Jacob taught it in a way that was interesting and engaging and the discussions allowed me to think on a deeper level. I really appreciated the way he ran discussions and how he posed questions that we were able to respond to and disagree with in a way that led to a deeper understanding of the topic.

Respect For Students

- ➢ Jacob did an excellent job teaching this course. He always acted as a very strong facilitator of the classroom enviornment that led to engaging class periods. He also made him self consistently available outside of class in order to put the students needs first. Overall, I think what really made him stand out as a teacher was the respect he showed to students that in turn encouraged participation in a great way.
- ➢ Jacob, I just wanted to say thank you for a great semester. Your class was without a doubt my favorite course this semester. I appreciate how clearly you explained things and how engaging you made the content. You gave attention to everyone's opinion and I could tell that everyone, including myself, gained respect for both each other and philosophy in general. Your class taught me to think more deeply and clearly. It also helped me to grow in my faith and get some concrete answers about questions I've had for a while. You are a gifted teacher and I wish you well in the future!

Fun :)

- Professor Zimbelman was an incredible professor and do hope I have him in class again in the future. He really knows how to balance old topics philsophical discussion and relate it to how we see and understand the world today. He explored new and stimulating ways to teach and knows how to argue about something and furthermore, have you question yourself. It was a lot of fun!
- I wanted to thank you for a great semester. Your class was one of my most enjoyable that I've had; I enjoyed hearing your perspective and thinking through some of the questions that you asked us throughout the course. I'm hopeful that I will see you around campus in the future!

---

§3 Sample Materials

Syllabuses

Courses I've Taught

Intro (instructor-led)
Intro (student-led)
Ethics (instructor-led, topical)
Ethics (instructor-led, Great Books style)

Courses I Hope to Teach

Epistemology
Conspiracy Theories
Social and Political Theory

Handouts

Intro

Epicureanism, Pleasure, & Pain
Rationalism & Empiricism
Taxes, Prisons, and Closed Borders
The Problem of Evil

Ethics

Consequentialism
Kant's Ethics
Theism and Morality
Psychological Egoism

Quizzes

Scientific realism & anti-realism
Descartes
Aquinas' five ways
Instinct and morality

"The Will to Believe"
Romantic love
Free will
The simulation argument